



Figure 1: Setting up the Canvas Application

Open Graph Protocol

We have often heard of the terms 'the semantic Web', 'Web 3.0' etc, and wonder what exactly they mean. Basically, adding semantics to Web pages makes them accessible for processing by machines, to recognise the meaning behind those pages on the Internet—making them more intelligent (no, not like what you saw in 'The Matrix').

The Open Graph Protocol is somewhat related to this; it lets Facebook know about the contents of a page, and about its classification information, etc. The structured data published by this protocol makes your Web page similar to a Facebook page, and makes it easier for users to access the data related to that page. It makes that information searchable on Facebook by converting it into a graph object that can appear anywhere on Facebook. This is the particular piece of technology that has given the 'Like' button so much popularity. The Open Graph Protocol can be implemented by using the good old `<meta>` tags and adding the *Like* button to the respective page, in the following manner:

```
<meta property="og:title" content="Linux For You Magazine"/>
<meta property="og:type" content="magazine"/>
<meta property="og:url" content="http://www.linuxforu.com"/>
<meta property="og:image" content="http://www.linuxforu.com/wp-content/themes/thestars/images/linux-for-u.gif"/>
<meta property="og:site_name" content="Linux For You"/>
<meta property="fb:admins" content="FACEBOOK_USERID_OF_ADMINS"/>
<meta property="og:description"
  content="The magazine aims at providing complete
  solution for deployment of Linux."/>
```

These tags can be added to the header of any page, which is then automatically available to Facebook for the easy extraction of information.

FQL

FQL is another heavily used feature provided by Facebook. As you might have guessed, it provides an SQL-like query interface to data exposed by the Facebook Graph API. Not only does it make accessing data easier, but also allows us to perform batch queries to the publicly available access point at:

https://api.facebook.com/method/fql.query?access_token=ACESSTOKENHERE&query=QUERY&format=json

Here, the query parameter value can be something like what follows:

```
SELECT name FROM user WHERE uid = me()
```

We can see that this query is like SQL, which most of us know, and makes advanced queries possible very easily. This query can also be executed at places other than this endpoint, such as via the JavaScript SDK, etc. Note that we need to have an access token before sending the FQL query to the server. We can also specify whether we want the response as XML or JSON, with the *format* parameter.

Canvas applications

When you want to set up an application on *facebook.com* and want it to appear within the Facebook domain, like the several games/applications encountered every day, you probably require canvas applications. All you need in order to make such applications is knowledge of your favourite Web programming language (PHP, Python, Java, etc), space to host that application somewhere, and some knowledge of the Facebook API. Now, to set up such an application, you need to set up a page (at most 760 pixels wide) somewhere on your Web server, and then configure it in the application settings under the Facebook integration tab, by setting the Canvas Page and Canvas URL property (see Figure 1).

Apart from these, Facebook also provides Custom Page Tabs that work in a manner similar to canvas applications. Full-fledged SDKs for Android, PHP, and JavaScript are available. They make Facebook development much easier, and have in-depth documentation and support. Also, the Ads API, Chat API and Credits API allow us to program with other advanced features that have not been listed here, as yet.

In conclusion, the features listed here are just an introduction. If you are serious about making your Web-app social, you should probably take a look at the incredible amount of documentation available at the developer website. **END** 

Further reading

- [1] Facebook Developers Documentation - <http://developers.facebook.com/docs/>
- [2] Facebook OAuth 2.0 Authentication Flow - <http://developers.facebook.com/docs/authentication/>

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